

Influence and Information: An Exploratory Investigation of the Boundary Role Person's Basis of Power

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This paper examines the boundary role person (BRP) as an influence agent and investigates an aspect of his potential ability to influence the decision outcomes of other organizational members. It was found that as their information requirements increase under conditions of higher perceived environmental uncertainty, the constituent members attribute to the BRP greater power in the decision making process. The results further suggest that, in light of the BRP's position in the transference of information across the organization's boundary, the reliance on expert power appears to be the most effective basis of social power for dealing with other organizational members.

The boundary role person (BRP) occupies a unique position in a firm's interaction with its environment (Adams, 1976). It has been hypothesized that as a firm's external environment becomes more turbulent and unstable the information processing function of the BRP becomes central to a firm's ability to effectively gather, analyze and act on relevant information (e.g., Aldrich & Herker, 1977; Leifer & Delbecq, 1978). The potential dependency relationship, growing from the BRP's ability to "cope with" (Thompson, 1967) or "absorb" (March & Simon, 1956) uncertainty for those other organizational members, affords boundary spanners an excellent opportunity to enhance their position of power within the organization. Recent anecdotal evidence suggests, for example, that much of the improved corporate status afforded to the purchasing function is a direct result of the severe materials shortages of 1973-74. Although eventual corporate recognition was inevitable, those turbulent environmental conditions served to hasten management's acknowledg-

ment of purchasing's important role in the acquisition, importation and processing of information crucial to the firm's survival.

Following in the tradition of Kahn, Wolfe, Quinn and Snoek (1964), researchers (e.g., Keller & Holland, 1975; Miles, 1976; Organ & Green, 1972; Wall & Adams, 1974) have focused on the conflicting influences exerted on BRPs by both their constituents (i.e., other members of the organization) and persons outside of their organization. From these studies has emerged a better understanding of affective factors which might impair a BRP's ability to effectively execute his important boundary spanning activities. Yet, a BRP is also a role sender—an influence agent—attempting to influence the decisions and behaviors of those individuals with whom he interacts. Not only must the BRP negotiate with BRPs from other firms who do not share the same goals and preference orderings (e.g., Frey & Adams, 1972), the boundary spanner must also, at times and to varying degrees, bargain with his own constituents. For example, Strauss (1962) has described the various power tactics of "bureaucratic gamesmanship" utilized by purchasing agents to enhance their position of influence during the procurement decision making process.

The purpose of this paper is to examine BRPs as influence agents by investigating aspects of their relationships with those constituents with whom they regularly interact during the performance of their jobs. Specifically, this paper focuses on the purchasing agent and his interactions with members of the buying task group (BTG) (i.e., those constituents responsible for purchasing related decisions). As it appears that the importance of the BRP's boundary spanning activities increases as the constituents require greater amounts of environmental information, one objective of this research is to examine whether the degree of power attributed to the purchasing agent by the other BTG members is associated with their level of perceived environmental uncertainty. The second objective deals with a related issue and focuses on the individual power-related behaviors of BRPs. Since BRPs, in general, have little if any formal authority over their constituents, the goal here is to examine what base(s) of social power purchasing agents utilize in their dealings with other BTG members.

POWER IN BOUNDARY ROLES

Attributed Power as a Function of Dependency

Viewing power as the inverse of dependency, Emerson (1962, p. 32) posited that "the dependence of actor *P* upon actor *O* is 1) directly proportional to *P*'s motivational investment in goals mediated by *O*; and 2) inversely proportional to the availability of those goals to *P* outside of the *O-P* relationship." Incorporating Emerson's conceptualization in an open systems framework, Thompson (1967) conceived of the organization

as an interdependent, decision making system in which the primary goal was to reduce the degree of uncertainty with which it had to contend. In response to unmanageable levels of environmental uncertainty, Thompson posited that organizations create specialized parts (i.e., boundary spanning units) to cope with these contingencies. As a result of this structural adaptation, boundary spanning units presumably foster an imbalanced dependency relationship among organizational subunits by devoting more energy to monitoring crucial environmental contingencies (see Aldrich & Herker, 1977; Thompson, 1967). Moreover, this increased boundary spanning activity places the BRP (here the purchasing agent) in the role of gatekeeper, thereby potentially increasing his or her ability to control, channel and reformulate available environmental information (Pettigrew, 1973; Rosen, 1976). Commenting on the important information processing function served by the BRP, Aldrich and Herker (1977) note that as constituents grow more dependent on the BRP's ability to filter the flow of information, the BRP's potential power position is further enhanced.

Hickson, Hinings, Lee, Schneck and Pennings (1971) have more formally presented the notion of intraorganizational power-dependency relations in a "strategic contingencies" model. Building on earlier research (e.g., Crozier, 1964; Emerson, 1962; Thompson, 1967), Hickson et al. (1971) posit two structural properties as conceptual determinants of power. They hypothesized that work flow centrality (i.e., the degree to which a subunit's activities are interlinked into the system) and non-substitutability (i.e., the ability of an organization to obtain alternative performance for the activities of a subunit) would contribute to the degree of organizational power. On one level, one can see that a degree of dependency (and, therefore, power) should accrue to purchasing by virtue of its specialized function and centrality to the work flow of the firm. Traditionally, however, purchasing agents were viewed as order takers/expeditors and, as a consequence, much of their boundary spanning activity was preempted by other departments. In many cases, the filtering and representative roles (see Adams, 1976; Miles, 1976) of the BRP were under-utilized and the potential boundary relevance of purchasing was not realized.

The need for purchasing agents, as BRPs, to heighten their monitoring activity was dramatically brought to the fore during the severe materials shortages of the mid-1970s. As the purchasing environment grew more turbulent, the purchasing agent's centrality became more salient, presumably, as a result of the crucial role played by a BRP in the acquisition, importation and processing of purchasing-related information. One can easily envision purchasing agents bolstering their unique gatekeeper role through their contacts with outside sales personnel, knowledge of potential and/or actual problems in the marketplace with respect to material availability, information regarding alternative sources or substitute material, and so on.

It can be seen that as a BRP is able to reduce uncertainty for the constituents responsible for purchasing-related decisions, they become dependent upon him/her as a source of information. Purporting that this dependency confers upon the BRP a position of power, both Crozier (1964) and Perrow (1972) observed that power tends to be related to the kind of uncertainty upon which depends the life of the firm. In the present context, the BTG is devoted to purchasing-related decision making. It is important to recognize, however, that it is not uncertainty per se that confers power; rather, it is the ability to cope with uncertainty that determines the degree of power achieved by the BRP. As the information demands of the constituents diminish—under conditions of lower environmental uncertainty—the coping mechanism becomes less crucial, the need to absorb uncertainty abates, and the BRP's power dissipates.

Power, in this context, is defined as the ability to influence decision making and is quite consistent with the definitions posited by Dahl (1957) and other power theorists. Further, it should be noted that the present conceptualization of power dependency parallels the Hickson et al. (1971) "strategic contingencies" paradigm and, as a result, is also shaped by structural constraints. In many respects, the preceding discussion suggests a latent power which must be exercised if the true impact of the BRP's power is to be realized. Similarly, Simon (1953) has suggested that the magnitude of a power resource might be employed as a measure of power. Thus, the actual power of a BRP is probably a function of the bases of power available to him at any given time. This distinction is maintained by Hickson et al. (1971, p. 218) who state "if the direction of the dependence in a relationship is determined by an imbalance of power bases, power itself must be defined separately from these bases."

Bases of Power and Constituent Compliance

Cyert and March (1964) were among the first to contradict the rationalistic approach to organizational decision making; they observed that since organizational members often do not share the same preference orderings, goals, et cetera, power is often exercised to affect decision outcomes. Indeed, as Schein (1977, p. 64) noted, "power struggles . . . may be as endemic to organizational life as planning, organizing, directing and controlling." Patchen (1974), building on the conceptual framework of French and Raven (1959), examined the various bases of power by which the various individuals participating in purchasing-related decisions exert more or less influence on procurement decision outcomes. Despite the fact that the research did not focus exclusively on the power bases exercised by purchasing agents (as BRPs) to further their influence, Patchen's study contributes to an understanding of the particular bases of power utilized to affect organizational decisions.

The decision to employ either a reward, coercive, expert, referent or legitimate base of power has certain consequences which may affect future

interactions and subsequent power attempts (Baldwin, 1971; Raven & Kruglanski, 1970). Not only do BRPs (or any influence agent, for that matter) have to weigh the costs associated with the exercise of power (see, Harsanyi, 1962), they must also consider the impact of their influence attempts on the long-run relationships with their constituents. For instance, although coercive and reward power are both socially dependent, requiring constant surveillance by the powerholder, the use of coercive power tends to result in heightened conflict and hostility. The exercise of reward power, on the other hand, appears to encourage continued interaction but is also less likely to contribute to a long-term power-dependent relationship, since the withdrawal of positive sanctions is apt to result in the less powerful person's reversion to his previous behavior. Further, the effect of the inducement, even if continued, is subject to diminishing utility.

The exercise of referent and/or expert power tends to foster a more cooperative, prolonged relationship between individuals. Expert and referent bases of power are seemingly more subtle in their impact, and research suggests that a degree of shared values and goal congruence may lie at the core of the emergent power dependent relationship (Raven & Kruglanski, 1970; Raven, 1974). The point is that if BRPs are to influence the decision outcomes of other constituent members, they need to devise tactics (i.e., power strategies) for most effectively dealing with these organizational members. In many cases, the decision can be quite problematic because BRPs do not have the traditional leverages of hierarchical authority (i.e., a legitimate basis of power) at their disposal (Cleland & King, 1968). Therefore, if BRPs are to successfully manifest their power, they need to develop a power strategy which is, at the same time, consistent with their base(s) of power and the consequence they desire (see, Schein, 1977).

Interestingly, Patchen's (1974) results suggest that influence on specific purchasing decisions often appears to be determined by those norms which accord influence to those with greatest stake in the decision. Of the five bases of power posited by French and Raven, expert power followed by legitimate power seemed to be the next two most frequently mentioned bases of influence. Patchen (1974, p. 216) also notes that reward, coercive power and, to a lesser extent, referent power were "noticeable chiefly by their absence." It should be noted again that this study did not attempt to isolate the bases of power exercised by a particular organizational member and, therefore, while furnishing important behavioral insights may not be directly transferable to an investigation of the specific power bases exercised by BRPs.

In an attempt to contribute to an understanding of the BRP as an influence agent, the present study examines two important research questions emerging from the literature cited above: (1) Is the level of power attributed to purchasing agents (as BRPs) associated with the level of their constituents' perceived environmental uncertainty, and (2) what bases of

social power are exercised by purchasing agents, as BRPs, to enhance their power position?

METHOD

The Sample

The sample consisted of 20 firms from the greater Chicago area. These firms represented 11 different industries of which 70 percent served mainly industrial markets and the remainder served mainly consumer markets. Using a sociometric technique (e.g., Patchen, 1974), BTG membership was determined by asking the purchasing agent the names and titles of those constituents with whom he interacted with respect to purchasing-related decisions for the commodity for which he was responsible. Purchasing agent centrality merely served to anchor a BTG's purchasing-related responsibility to a particular commodity. While each decision represented a commodity (21 different classes ranging from edible fats, to steel, to metal fasteners) which was of considerable importance to each firm in the sample, the study focused on rather repetitive purchasing decisions. More specifically, each procurement decision typified a modified rebuy situation in which the various BTG members "...have relevant buying experiences, but the experience factor is not complete because new alternative suppliers, items or marketing services are being considered" (Robinson, Faris & Wind, 1967, p. 26).

Defined as an informal decision making unit (see, Spekman, 1977), the BTG exemplifies a conceptualization of the lateral relationships (often cutting across formal lines of authority) which emerge as a result of the procurement process. The focus of the BTG is on the relationships which develop between the purchasing agent and those other organizational actors (i.e., production/manufacturing people, R&D engineers, quality control personnel, sales managers and the like) with whom he/she interacts during the purchasing decision making process. In this fashion, the BTG defines a measurable communications network in which the objective is making purchasing-related decisions for a particular commodity or class of commodities.

Each BTG members' questionnaire accentuated the interactive, multiperson nature of the procurement process. (The reader can obtain copies of the research instrument from the author.) Moreover, the respondents were told that they were designated as members of a particular BTG "because part of your job entails interacting with a purchasing agent with respect to the decision to purchase commodity X." (Towards the end of the questionnaire, each respondent was asked to respond to the question: "To what extent do you feel you are a part of the buying task group?" All respondents retained in the final sample affirmed their participation in the BTG.) During March-April 1976, 400

respondents were either personally administered or mailed questionnaires. In total, there were 322 usable questionnaires (an 80.5 percent response rate).

Measures

Environmental Uncertainty—With full recognition of the debate regarding the use of objective versus perceptual measures of environmental uncertainty (see Downey & Slocum, 1975; Tosi, Aldag & Storey, 1973), an 11-item, perceptual measure of uncertainty ($\alpha = .68$) was adopted from Duncan (1972). In order to capture the relevant task environment, the scale was modified to (1) focus exclusively on purchasing-related decisions and (2) reflect the entire range of information inputs impinging on the BTG. Specifically, attention was given to purchasing relevant factors external to the BTG but internal to the firm as well as factors external to both the BTG and the firm. The following questions will illustrate the distinction between the domains of the relevant task environment:

Relative to your role in the BTG, how often are you certain about what procedures would be best for dealing with purchasing related problems that arise outside your company?

Relative to your role in the BTG, how often are you certain about what procedures would be best for dealing with purchasing related problems that arise in other departments in your company?

It can be seen, therefore, that purchasing decisions can be affected by such external factors as government regulations and economic conditions as well as by internal considerations with respect to material tolerances, production estimates, sales forecasts and so on.

Attributed Power—The power construct ($\alpha = .78$) focused on the degree to which the purchasing agent was perceived by his constituents to influence the purchasing decision making process. Consistent with other power theorists (e.g., March, 1955), attributed power was utilized to measure the influence of the purchasing agent within the BTG. As the scope of this study was limited to the procurement process, a specific item measure (Patchen, 1963), adopted from the Robinson et al.'s (1967) "buy phase," was employed to access the purchasing agent's influence in the sequence of decision making activities which are performed during the purchasing process. Specifically, the power scale examined the purchasing agent's influence in an eight-step succession of purchasing-related events beginning with "problem recognition and/or anticipation" and ending with the "evaluation and inspection of goods upon delivery."

The Bases of Social Power—The operationalization of the French and Raven typology presented several difficulties, not the least of which was the lack of a clear external criterion. A 15-item scale was constructed to tap the bases of social power (i.e., three items for each power base). Reflecting a high degree of face validity, these questions examined the

reasons other BTG members state they "follow suggestions or fulfill requests made by the purchasing agent." The operationalization of the power bases was depicted as:

- (Reward) "He can give special help to those who cooperate with him."
- (Coercive) "He can penalize those who do not follow his suggestions."
- (Legitimate) "He has a legitimate right, considering his position, to expect that his suggestions will be carried out."
- (Referent) "I respect him personally, and want to act in a way that merits his respect and admiration."
- (Expert) "I defer to his judgment in areas in which he is more familiar than I."

A factor analysis, using VARIMAX rotation, was utilized to examine whether the "bases of power" scale did, indeed, represent five distinct constructs, each tapping a unique conceptual space. Such a "single common factor" approach has an implicit objective of construct validity. In effect, an operational measure is a valid measure of a construct if it relates in the way that a concept "should" to measures of other related constructs. As can be seen from Table 1, the factor analysis extracted four factors with eigenvalues greater than 1.0. It is interesting to note that all three of the expert power scale items (factor III) loaded heavily on one factor. Reward, referent and, to a lesser degree, legitimate power loaded heavily on two factors (factors I and II), thus appearing to tap a conceptual property space which can be described as a more inclusive, noncoercive base of power. This more complex construct seems to support the notion that the bases of power are rarely used independently and, specifically, referent power is often exercised in combination with one or more of the power bases (Raven, 1971). It can be seen that the ambiguous distinction between referent power and other power bases is accentuated further by the high factor loading of a referent power scale item on factor III (expert power). Finally, factor IV is suggestive of a coercive base of power but, due to the mixed loadings of the coercive power base items, must be subject to guarded interpretation.

It should be noted that in an effort to avoid the operational difficulties associated with the French and Raven typology, marketing researchers (e.g., Hunt & Nevin, 1974; Lusch, 1976) have abandoned the five bases schema and have, instead, adopted a coercive/noncoercive power base classification. While this consolidation achieves parsimony and solves many empirical problems associated with differentiating the bases of power, it is felt that this approach also loses valuable information. Since an objective here is to more fully investigate the various power bases exercised by BRPs in their attempts to influence constituent decision processes, a compromise approach was utilized. Rather than retain the five bases as independent constructs due to the high intercorrelations among

TABLE 1
A Factor Analysis of the Bases of Social Power

<i>Scale Items Denoting the Base of Social Power</i>	<i>Factor I</i>	<i>Factor II</i>	<i>Factor III</i>	<i>Factor IV</i>
I respect him personally, and want to act in a way that merits his respect and admiration	<u>.711</u>	.200	.341	-.035
I respect his competence about things he is more experienced than I	.371	-.003	<u>.642</u>	-.232
He can give special help to those who cooperate with him	<u>.771</u>	.094	.119	.285
He can apply pressure on those who do not cooperate with him	.616	-.038	-.103	.564
He has a legitimate right, considering his position, to expect that his suggestions will be carried out	.115	.029	.102	.120
I defer to his judgment in areas in which he is more familiar than I	.088	-.086	<u>.850</u>	.207
He can make things difficult for me if I fail to follow his advice	.434	.087	.011	<u>.630</u>
Because he is the purchasing agent I am obligated to follow his suggestions	.152	.511	-.023	.268
I can personally benefit by cooperating with him	.672	.349	.067	.302
Following his advice results in better decisions	.069	.223	.547	-.025
I cooperate with him because I have high regard for him as an individual	.282	.406	.640	-.036
He can penalize those who do not follow his suggestions	.236	.162	.050	<u>.751</u>
I feel I have to cooperate with him	.001	.457	-.008	<u>.649</u>
I cooperate with him because I wish to be identified with him	.273	<u>.794</u>	-.050	.117
Cooperating with him can positively impact on my performance	.065	<u>.762</u>	.232	.201
Eigenvalue	5.06	2.03	1.32	1.02
Percentage of Cumulative Variance Explained	33.7	47.2	56.0	62.8

the power bases (see Table 2), the two highest factor scores on each extracted factor were combined to create four bases of power (i.e., noncoercive I and II, expert and coercive.)¹ In this manner, problems associated with multicollinearity were minimized and much of the descriptive information of the five-base schema could be retained.

ANALYSIS AND DISCUSSION

While Allen (1966) discusses the flow of information across boundaries as a technical problem, Pettigrew (1972) and others conceive of the BRP's unique position in the information flow as a potential power resource.

¹ Although a legitimate power item had a higher factor loading on the coercive power factor (factor IV) than the second coercive power item, it was not included in the final model. Exclusion of the legitimate power item was based primarily on the greater difference between the mixed loading scores on the second coercive power item.

TABLE 2
Zero-Order Correlation Matrix of the Bases of Social Power ($n = 206$)

	<i>REFPOW</i>	<i>EXPOW</i>	<i>REWPOW</i>	<i>COERPOW</i>	<i>LEGPOW</i>
Referent Power (REFPOW)	1.00	.455***	.605***	.401***	.465***
Expert Power (EXPOW)		1.00	.317***	.124*	.193**
Reward Power (REWPOW)			1.00	.607***	.496***
Coercive Power (COERPOW)				1.00	.554***
Legitimate Power (LEGPOW)					1.00

* $p < .05$
 ** $p < .01$
 *** $p < .001$

These findings support the positive relationship between the level of perceived uncertainty and the power attributed to the purchasing agent ($r = .351, p < .01$). It can be inferred that the power of the purchasing agent emanates from a dependency built on the flow of material (Hickson et al., 1971 refer to this as work flow centrality) and the flow of information. Since the importance of purchasing to the continued flow of production goods is felt to be relatively constant regardless of the level of uncertainty, the positive correlation seems to suggest that coping with uncertainty fosters a greater dependency as the perceived level of uncertainty increases.

The notion of dependency is reinforced by further analysis suggesting that BTG members operating under conditions of greater uncertainty perceive purchasing to exercise greater influence in other than purchasing related issues than those BTG members operating under conditions of lesser perceived uncertainty ($t = -4.80, p < .01$). While the actual scope of the purchasing agent's influence was not probed, the point is that BRPs (in their gatekeeper role) sit at the juncture of many communication paths and, therefore, collect and filter information that can potentially impact upon the decision outcomes of many constituents, some of whom share no regularized task related activities with the purchasing agent. It can easily be envisioned that as long as the purchasing agent is perceived to effectively filter and channel environmental information, and the information is deemed crucial, the scope of his/her power can presumably extend to such diverse areas as product design, long-range planning and other traditionally nonpurchasing areas.

Related to the notion of power dependency is the issue of the means by which BRPs, as influence agents, exhibit their power. Table 3 summarizes data examining the power-related behavior utilized by the purchasing agent in his/her power attempts. In many respects, this model is felt to depict the strategies by which the purchasing agent's power becomes

TABLE 3

The Basis of Power as Predictors of Power: Multiple Regression Summary Table

<i>Independent Variables</i>	<i>Beta Weight</i>	<i>Cumulative R²</i>	<i>F (to add)</i>
Expert Power	.356	.139	25.80**
Coercive	-.067	.142	0.73
Noncoercive I	.079	.145	0.94
Noncoercive II	-.043	.146	0.37
Overall Model			8.61*

* $p < .01$ ** $p < .001$

manifest. It becomes readily apparent that the significance of the entire model ($F = 8.61$, $p < .01$) and slightly over 90 percent of the explained variance (13.9 percent) is directly attributable to the expert base of power. This finding is consistent with the notion that the BRP's base of power is primarily a result of his ability to gather and filter information deemed crucial by his constituents. Whether as a result of the purchasing agent's experience, access to information, or familiarity with purchasing-related issues, the BTG members appear to rely on the BRP to improve their decision outcomes. Conceptually, and from the perspective of the BRP, the utilization of expert power leads to greater cooperation and heightened dependence (see Raven & Kruglanski, 1970). Interestingly, Strauss (1962) observed that those purchasing agents concerned with improving their status and expanding their influence tended to rely on "educational tactics" which could easily be interpreted as the development of expert power-based behavior. From the perspective of the BTG members, however, other research indicates that a strong dependency can be problematic, since BRPs can conceal and misrepresent information, thereby presenting to their constituents a distorted, self-serving view of the environment (Rosen & Adams, 1976).

A tendency to rely on expert power is mirrored in findings by Patchen (1974), who reported that a person's knowledge, experience or access to information were frequently mentioned as reasons an individual was influential in a decision. It is interesting to note that while Patchen (1974) also observed the use of legitimate power (or authority) as a prevalent basis of power, legitimate power was not included in the final model by virtue of its poor and/or mixed factor loadings. Since the purchasing agent has no formal authority over other BTG members, it is not surprising to find that legitimate power is not a viable power source in the present context. Moreover, Strauss (1962) noted that "rule oriented" tactics were not employed by the more influential purchasing agents who preferred to operate informally so that they could more easily "bend the rules" to achieve their own objectives.

The reader is cautioned, however, not to interpret these findings as suggesting that BRPs rely *solely* on expert power in order to influence decision outcomes. From Table 4 it can be seen that one of the noncoercive

TABLE 4
Zero-Order Correlation Matrix Between Attributed Power
and the Bases of Social Power

	<i>Noncoercive Power I</i>	<i>Noncoercive Power II</i>	<i>Expert Power</i>	<i>Coercive Power</i>
Attributed Power	.1463*	-.0113	.3635**	-.0095

* $p < .05$

** $p < .001$

power bases is also related to attributed power ($r = .146$, $p < .05$), although there is a significantly stronger association between attributed power and expert power ($p < .05$). (Hotellings' t was used to test for the significance of the differences between the two correlation coefficients.) This finding seems to accentuate the nebulous distinction between expert power and the other noncoercive power bases. This correlation matrix serves to temper the above discussion and tends to suggest that while expert power emerges as the dominant explanatory power base, its effective utilization may be tied, to some extent, to the BRP's exercise of a combination of power bases—in this case, other noncoercive power bases.

The weak support given to the BRP's utilization of referent power (as a component of the noncoercive power-based factors) is consistent with Patchen's findings (1974). Yet, both Adams (1976) and Organ (1971) recommend developing a referent power base as a viable strategy for BRPs to compensate for their lack of formal authority when dealing across boundaries. These findings seem to indicate that reliance on referent power alone may not be a successful tactic for the present sample of purchasing agents. This discrepancy may be due, in part, to the present research context. That is, since purchasing is perceived by many to be a low-status position, it would follow presumably that the purchasing agent would not serve as a basis for association and/or identification. While generalization beyond this research setting may be tenuous, it is interesting to note that both reward and referent power converge on the same factor. Perhaps this indicates that purchasing agents, cognizant of their lower status, attempt to gain and/or enhance personal loyalty and respect by "buying" (i.e., rewarding) their constituents.

The use of coercive power does not appear to be a suitable power base for dealing with constituents. Patchen (1974, p. 216) interprets the absence of sanctions (both rewards and punishments) as a result of demand characteristics emanating from a "reluctance to talk about such models of influence." A richer explanation, probing the interpersonal dynamics of the procurement process, might reflect the costs associated with the exercise of sanctions. That is, if a purchasing agent threatens another BTG member with certain reprisals for nonperformance of a specified behavior and the threat is not carried out, the purchasing agent has suffered a loss of credibility. Further, the use of rewards, while more conducive to

prolonged compliance, may lead to strained relationships because some constituents may come to expect favors and the purchasing agent's repertoire of rewards is quite limited.

Finally, it should be noted that while these findings appear to substantiate the conceptual relationship between environmental uncertainty and the power attributed to the purchasing agent as well as the purchasing agent's subsequent reliance on expert power, these results are subject to guarded interpretation. Given that the purchasing agent has traditionally been viewed as a low-status corporate member who often had no input whatsoever into the purchasing decision making process, it is not surprising to find the absolute mean score of the attributed power construct is rather low ($\bar{X} = 2.282$, range = 1.82). (The power construct was measured on a five-point Likert scale with a score of 1 connoting "little, or no influence.") Therefore, the low overall score may be viewed as reflecting relative measures of high and low power, remembering that the enduring "order-taker stereotype would probably mollify the opportunity for the purchasing agent to achieve a great deal of absolute influence during the purchasing process.

CONCLUSION

This exploratory field research has empirically investigated aspects of the conceptual linkage between boundary spanning activity and the information requirements of the BRP's constituent members. The BRP has been examined as an influence agent and his base of power has been shown to emerge from his potential ability to channel, if not control, the flow of information into his firm. It can be inferred from these findings that the purchasing agent's tendency to rely more heavily on expert power supports the notion that the BRP's power resides primarily in his ability to cope with uncertainty for his constituents. Moreover, these findings suggest that the exercise of expert power is a means by which a BRP can better sustain a continued dependency relationship thereby assuring himself an influential voice in the decision making process. Despite the contextual limitations of this study, this research has reaffirmed the importance of the boundary role person in the acquisition, importation and processing of environmental information.

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